

spotlight, but the groundwork is almost always in place. What the league does exceptionally well is facilitate discovery.

While it can sometimes feel like a launchpad, the WPL is a place where players arrive raw and leave internationally ready. But the reality is more layered. As the league continues to expand the talent pool, the national women's team cannot absorb every breakout star immediately.

Moreover, not every WPL breakthrough sustains its momentum. For every player who turns a strong season into a permanent step forward, others stall after the initial surge. Sayali Satghare, Saima Thakor, Saika Ishaque, Kiran Navgire and Bharti Fulmali have all looked ready at different points, earned senior opportunities, yet struggled to hold their place.

This season, however, has reopened doors for some. Strong WPL performances have brought Bharti and Sayali back into the national setup ahead of the upcoming tour of Australia, a reminder of how quickly the league can restore visibility.

The WPL certainly offers a month-long peak, but international cricket demands more than that. What is required is consistent exposure to elite intensity. According to those working inside India's development pipeline, the answer lies in what happens long before and after a WPL season.

The engine room

Behind every player making an impact is a system designed to ensure readiness from the start. Age-group tournaments, emerging training camps and a layered development structure create a pathway that has proven highly effective, according to Nooshin Al Khadeer, who works closely with India's domestic, emerging, Under-19 and A squads. "Domestic players who perform at Under-19, Under-23 and senior levels are picked

Future icons: Anushka

Sharma's 360-degree strokeplay and calm confidence marked a player ready for the big stages. **Facing page:** In her breakout season, Nandini Sharma turned out to be a fearless pacer with rare control in the death overs. PTI

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